

Coaching & Growing Others

Session 02 · Brillio Academy · Learning & Development

This reading is a standalone document. It does not summarise the session slides. It expands the research, extends the frameworks, and gives you the applied tools to take this into a real conversation this week.

The ideas here are more useful the second time you encounter them — in a 1:1, in a moment of difficulty, in a conversation where the instinct is to give the answer and you choose not to.

The Research: What the Evidence Actually Shows

The Manager Effect

Gallup's 2025 State of the Global Workplace report found that 70% of team engagement variance is explained by the direct manager. Not the organisation's strategy. Not the company's benefits package. Not the culture statement on the wall. The person who shows up to the weekly 1:1.

The same report found that global employee engagement fell to 21% in 2024 — the lowest figure in a decade. Manager engagement itself hit 22%, the steepest single-year decline on record. The people most responsible for developing others are among the least engaged themselves.

This is not a management failure. It is a development failure. Most managers were promoted for what they could do — their technical expertise, their delivery record, their individual contribution. Almost none were formally taught how to develop the people around them.

Being a good coach is the single most important behaviour distinguishing the best managers from the rest.

Google Project Oxygen, 2008 — refreshed 2018

Google Project Oxygen: What the Research Actually Found

In 2008, Google's People Analytics team ran an internal study to answer a question the company had quietly debated for years: do managers actually matter? They analysed over 10,000 data points from performance reviews, manager surveys, and employee feedback. The answer was unambiguous — managers matter enormously, and the single most important behaviour was coaching.

The finding was counterintuitive inside a company built on technical brilliance. Google engineers had long assumed that the best managers were the ones who understood the code. Project Oxygen found the opposite: technical expertise ranked last of the ten behaviours. The behaviours that mattered most were human — listening, asking, developing, creating psychological safety.

When Google subsequently trained managers in these behaviours, the measurable outcomes improved: teams reported higher satisfaction, lower attrition, and stronger performance ratings. The research has been replicated, updated, and validated in multiple subsequent studies.

Google People Analytics (2008, refreshed 2018)

Project Oxygen — What Makes a Great Manager?

Analysed 10,000+ data points from performance reviews and manager surveys. Being a good coach ranked #1 of 10 manager behaviours. Technical expertise ranked #10. Training managers in these behaviours improved turnover, satisfaction, and team performance across functions.

The Effectiveness of Coaching: What the Academic Research Shows

In 2016, Jones, Woods, and Guillaume published a meta-analysis of 17 workplace coaching studies in the Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology. Their findings were striking: coaching demonstrated positive effects on performance outcomes overall, with an effect size of $\delta=0.36$. At the individual level — when measuring specific results, skill development, and behavioural change — the effect size rose to $\delta=1.24$.

To put that in context: an effect size above 0.8 is considered large in social science research. Coaching at the individual level outperforms most managerial training interventions by a significant margin. The study also found that coaching was most effective when combined with goal-setting and when the coach held genuine belief in the coachee's capability.

Jones, R.J., Woods, S.A. & Guillaume, Y.R.F. (2016)

The effectiveness of workplace coaching: A meta-analysis — Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 89(2), 249–277.

Meta-analysis of 17 studies. Overall effect size $\delta=0.36$. Individual-level results $\delta=1.24$ — outperforming managerial training alone. Effectiveness increased when coaching was combined with explicit goal-setting and genuine coach belief in coachee capability.

Forrester Research (2025)

Managers Who Coach Their Employees Drive High Engagement — Future of Work Survey.

54% of workers describe their manager as a coach. Employees with a coaching manager are 8x more likely to be highly engaged than those without. The engagement gap between coached and non-coached employees widens significantly at senior levels.

Why Coaching Does Not Happen: The Four Blockers

The research is clear. The case is compelling. Most managers who encounter it agree that coaching matters. And then they go back to their 1:1s and give advice. The gap between understanding and practice is where development lives. Here is what actually gets in the way — and what is true instead.

1. “I don’t have time.”

This is the most cited reason and the most misunderstood one. The assumption embedded in it is that coaching takes more time than not coaching. It does not — not over any meaningful timeframe.

A 10-minute coaching conversation that helps a team member resolve their own problem takes 10 minutes. The same problem left uncoached typically returns — either as a repeated issue, an escalation, or a dependency pattern where the person routinely comes back to the manager for the answer. The time cost accumulates on the manager’s side, not the team member’s.

The more precise framing: coaching is a time investment, not a time cost. The return is a team member who handles more independently — which eventually gives the manager time back.

2. “I give feedback — isn’t that coaching?”

Feedback and coaching are related but distinct. Feedback is retrospective — it names what happened, what the impact was, and what should change. Coaching is prospective — it builds the person’s capacity to navigate what comes next.

Giving someone feedback on a difficult stakeholder conversation tells them how that conversation landed. Coaching them before or after it builds the person who handles the next one differently. Both are valuable. Neither replaces the other.

The confusion arises because good feedback conversations often contain coaching elements — especially when they include Intent (as in the SBI-I model). But feedback that stops at Impact is not coaching. It is evaluation.

3. “I ask open questions — I must be coaching.”

The format of coaching — open questions, active listening, non-directive conversation — can be mimicked without the substance of coaching being present. The test is not the format of the conversation. It is the outcome.

The question to ask after any conversation: who left with the solution? If the manager left with it — or supplied it — the conversation was not coaching, regardless of how many open questions were asked. If the team member left with it — having surfaced it themselves — it was.

Directing with open questions is still directing. The critical variable is ownership: who holds the problem, the thinking, and the next action at the end of the conversation.

4. “I only coach when there is a problem.”

This is the most costly of the four blockers because it is the hardest to see. When coaching is reserved for remedial situations — performance issues, conflicts, failures — it becomes

associated with problems rather than growth. Team members learn to dread coaching conversations rather than welcome them.

The most impactful coaching happens proactively: with high performers, before a stretch assignment, during a period of successful delivery. This is where capability compounds fastest. Waiting for a problem means the manager is always reacting.

Developmental coaching — regular, forward-looking conversations with people who are already performing well — is where the return on coaching is highest.

The Five Principles of Coaching

These are not techniques to apply. They are a way of showing up in a conversation. The difference matters: techniques can be deployed without genuine engagement. Principles cannot.

1. Awareness before action

Most coaching conversations fail because the manager starts solving before the real issue has surfaced. The presenting problem — the one the team member names in the first two sentences — is rarely the most important one. Awareness means staying in the problem long enough to understand it fully before moving toward resolution.

The practical discipline: resist the urge to respond to the first thing you hear. Ask one more question. Then another. The actual issue almost always surfaces in the third or fourth exchange, not the first.

2. Questions before answers

A well-placed question does more than a well-crafted answer. The coachee who finds their own answer owns it — and acts on it. The one who receives an answer may or may not.

This is not about withholding support. It is about choosing the more generous act. Giving someone your answer keeps the thinking inside your head. Asking a question that helps them find theirs transfers it permanently.

3. Ownership stays with the coachee

The moment a manager rescues a team member from discomfort — by supplying the answer, solving the problem, or taking over the action — ownership transfers back to the manager. This is the most common and most costly failure mode in coaching.

Discomfort in a coaching conversation is usually the signal that the coachee is close to their own insight. The instinct to resolve that discomfort by helping is understandable. But acting on it forfeits the learning that was about to happen.

The discipline: hold the space. Let the silence work. Ask “what do you think?” and mean it.

4. Belief precedes capability

Whitmore's foundational argument in *Coaching for Performance* is that the coach's job is to raise awareness and transfer responsibility. Embedded in that is something less often named: the coach must believe the coachee is capable of more than they currently demonstrate, and that belief must be genuine.

Belief expressed through questions — “what would you do if you had no constraints?” — often unlocks thinking the coachee did not know they had. The question works because the coach's genuine curiosity signals that the answer is expected. That expectation changes what the coachee produces.

5. Consistency over intensity

One 60-minute coaching session per quarter does less than four 15-minute conversations per month. Coaching as a discipline is built through repetition, not events. The annual development review, however well-structured, cannot substitute for consistent developmental attention throughout the year.

The practical implication: the goal is not to have a perfect coaching conversation. It is to have a coaching conversation. Regularly. With each person on the team. The quality improves with practice. The relationship deepens with consistency.

The GROW Framework: A Thinking Structure

GROW was developed by Sir John Whitmore, Graham Alexander, and Alan Fine in the 1980s and published in Whitmore's *Coaching for Performance* in 1992. It has become the most widely used coaching framework in organisational settings because it is simple enough to remember and flexible enough to work across a wide range of conversations.

It is important to understand what GROW is and what it is not. It is a thinking structure — a map of where a coaching conversation needs to travel to be complete. It is not a script. The questions listed below are starting points, not formulas. The best coaching questions emerge from genuine curiosity about the specific person and situation in front of you.

G — Goal: What does good look like?

The Goal stage is about establishing what success looks like — not for the task, but for the person. A common facilitation error is conflating the task goal (deliver the project) with the developmental goal (feel confident managing stakeholder disagreement). GROW works best when both are in view.

- “What would a good outcome look like — for you, not just the project?”
- “How will you know when you have got there?”
- “What would make this outcome meaningful to you personally?”
- “What does success feel like from the inside?”

R — Reality: What is actually happening?

Reality is where the coach's most important discipline lives: staying curious rather than solution-oriented. The temptation at this stage is to hear the first description of the problem and start solving. Good coaching holds in Reality long enough to understand fully.

- “What is actually happening right now?”
- “What have you already tried? What did you notice?”
- “What is getting in the way?”
- “On a scale of 1 to 10, how confident do you feel about this — and what would move it one point higher?”

O — Options: What could be done?

Options is where creativity lives. The coach's job here is to expand the coachee's thinking beyond their first response. Most people stop generating options when they find a plausible one. The ‘what else?’ question is the most powerful tool in this stage.

- “What could you do? What else? What haven't you considered yet?”
- “If you had no constraints, what would you try?”
- “What would you tell a colleague in the same situation?”
- “What would someone you admire do here?”

W — Will: What will actually happen?

Will is where ownership is confirmed. The distinction between Options and Will is the difference between possibility and commitment. A good Will conversation leaves no ambiguity about what the coachee will do, by when, and what support they need.

- “What will you commit to? By when?”
- “What might get in the way — and how will you handle it?”
- “What support do you need from me?”
- “How will you know if this is working?”

One important note on sequencing: GROW works best in order, but skilled coaches know when to move back a stage. If the coachee's goal shifts mid-conversation — because Reality revealed something unexpected — return to Goal before continuing. The model is a guide, not a cage.

SBI-I: When Coaching Needs Direct Feedback

Coaching and feedback are not the same thing. But they work together. There are moments in a developmental conversation when a specific behaviour needs to be named directly — when staying in coaching mode would be evasive rather than supportive. SBI-I (developed by the Centre for Creative Leadership) provides a structure for those moments.

The Four Components

- **When and where the behaviour occurred. Specific and observable, not general.** “In Tuesday’s client review” not “recently” or “frequently.” Situation:
- **What specifically happened — observable action, not interpretation.** “You presented without the data the client had asked for” not “you were unprepared.” Behaviour:
- **What the behaviour affected. Be specific about the consequence.** “It created doubt in the room about our preparation” not “it wasn’t good.” Impact:
- **The question that opens it up.** “Help me understand what was happening for you at that point.” This is where SBI becomes SBI-I — and where feedback becomes coaching. Intent:

The last I — Intent — is where SBI-I becomes a coaching conversation. You stop telling and start asking. That shift is everything.

Three Worked Examples

The following examples show SBI-I applied across three different workplace situations. In each case, the Intent question is what opens the conversation from evaluation to exploration.

Example 1: A team member misses a deadline without warning.

“In the Apollo project last week (S), the deliverable was not submitted by the agreed Friday deadline and I was not notified in advance (B). The client had to be told there would be a delay, which affected the relationship (I). Help me understand what was happening on your end (I).”

Example 2: A team member dominates a meeting in a way that closes down others.

“In yesterday’s team review (S), you shared your perspective on each agenda item before others had a chance to contribute (B). I noticed two colleagues chose not to speak after the first few minutes (I). What was going on for you in that conversation (I)?”

Example 3: A team member escalates a problem to senior leadership without looping in their manager.

“When the client issue came up on Thursday (S), you escalated directly to the VP without bringing me in first (B). It meant I was responding to questions without context, which made us look uncoordinated (I). Walk me through what you were thinking at that point (I).”

In each example, the Intent question is not rhetorical. It is a genuine invitation. The manager does not know what was happening for the team member — and the answer to that question determines what kind of support is actually needed.

Application Scenarios: Advice vs. Coaching

The following three scenarios show the same situation handled in two ways. Read both responses and consider which elements of the session's frameworks are in play.

Situation	Advice response	Coaching response
Team member says they are struggling with confidence in client meetings.	"I felt the same early in my career. Just be more prepared — over-prepare for every meeting and your confidence will come."	"Tell me about a meeting where you felt confident. What was different about that one? What would it take to recreate those conditions?"
Team member misses a deadline and comes to explain what happened.	"This can't happen again. Here's what you need to do next time: set interim milestones and flag risks earlier."	"What got in the way? What did you notice about how you were managing the work? What would you do differently if this situation came up again?"
Team member wants to discuss a conflict with a peer.	"I'll have a word with them. These things happen — just stay professional and don't let it affect your work."	"What have you tried so far? What outcome would feel like a resolution to you? What would it take for you to have that conversation directly?"

Questions Worth Sitting With

These are not exercises. They are questions worth returning to over the next week as you have real conversations at work.

1. Think of the person on your team (or in your peer group) who would benefit most from a coaching conversation. What has stopped you from having it?
2. In your last five 1:1s, who left with the solution — you or them? What does that tell you about where you are in your coaching practice?
3. Which of the five principles do you find hardest to hold? What does that cost the people you work with?
4. Think of the best coaching conversation you have ever been in — as the coachee. What made it different? What did the coach do that you have not yet done yourself?
5. If you commit to one GROW conversation per week for the next four weeks, who would benefit most — and what would you want to understand about them by the end of it?

Further Reading

For those who want to go deeper on the ideas introduced in this session:

- **Essential:** Whitmore, J. (2019) — Coaching for Performance (5th ed.). Nicholas Brealey. The foundational text.
 - **For practice:** Starr, J. (2021) — The Coaching Manual (5th ed.). Pearson. Practical and accessible.
 - **For the data:** Gallup (2025) — State of the Global Workplace 2025. Available at [gallup.com](https://www.gallup.com).
 - **For the research:** Jones, R.J. et al. (2016) — Journal of Occupational and Organizational Psychology, 89(2). The full meta-analysis is accessible via most university library portals.
 - **On feedback & coaching:** Scott, K. (2019) — Radical Candor. Macmillan. On the relationship between caring personally and challenging directly.
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The people who develop other people are the ones who ask better questions — not because they don't have the answers, but because they know the question is the more generous act.

END OF POST-SESSION READING